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Art Analysis 1 - Masaccio, *Holy Trinity*

Masaccio's *Holy Trinity*, Santa Maria Novella, c. 1425-1427, when read from bottom to top tells a familiar story to the viewer of Christ's triumph over death. At the bottom, eye level of the viewer, a skeleton on a sarcophagus serves as a palpable reminder of human mortality. Above this, the two donor portraits face the center bringing us inward and their kneeling and covered heads remind us both of Christ's divinity and the somber scene of the crucifixion. The triumphal arch creates a physical "frame" that separates the divine realm of Christ and the Father from the church floor with the donors and the viewers. While this clear threshold sets the sacred apart, we as viewers are also invited in by the striking use of linear perspective, developed by Brunelleschi, drawing us to the vanishing point at the base of the cross. In the middle stand Saint John and the Virgin Mary, pointing towards Christ and facing the viewer, perhaps encapsulating the Catholic practice of treating Mary as a conduit of prayer to God. Above this God the father is holding up the cross and the dove of the Holy Spirit going between God the Father and God the Son as a symbol of the holy trinity. Framing this we have a coffered barrel vaulted arch reminiscent of Roman triumphal arches, which reminds the viewer not to be too sad at the crucifixion as Christ ultimately resurrects. The arch symbolizes his triumph over death (and perhaps also his triumph over the pagan religion of the Romans) as Masaccio quite literally places him standing over the *memento mori*, which he uses to represent it.

Beyond the simple placement of figures the colors themselves reinforce the biblical narrative. We make notice of the use of blue and red throughout the artwork. We may take blue to signify divinity, heaven, and the sky and red to signify Christ's passion, blood, and ultimate humanity. Mary is robed in a typical blue gown placing her as the Queen of Heaven, a sinless

and immaculate figure. John the Baptist is in red representing both his humanity and prefiguring his eventual martyrdom. God the Father's robes are both red and blue, representing the union of divinity with humanity. Noticeably, Christ's garments break this blue-red motif, which is present in the robes of the donors, arches, and coffers, with only a white loin cloth. The brilliance of the cloth is rivaled only in the painting by the Holy Spirit's depiction as a white dove and this immediately draws the viewer to the Christ figure. The pristine loincloth remains unstained despite the gruesome crucifixion as a representation of spotless lamb of God and the miracle of the eventual resurrection.

Ultimately Masaccio's *Holy Trinity* serves as an educational window into the Holy Trinity for the then everyday illiterate churchgoer. The classical architecture and mathematical precision of linear perspective provide a sense of order and balance like the assuredness of faith. Whereas the coloration of blue, red, and white provides an emotional narrative of the divinity, passion, suffering, death, and salvation of the biblical narrative.